



ADHD IN RUGBY

Resource 3

A Neurodiverse Sport Publication produced
in collaboration with England Rugby

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NdS
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ADHD in Rugby

This resource is the third in a series aimed at deepening your understanding of neurodiversity in rugby and building practical neuroinclusive coaching skills.

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For the best foundation, we recommend reading the resources in sequence. Together, they support coaches, players, and the community in creating environments where both neurodivergent and neurotypical individuals can thrive. Neuroinclusive practices benefit everyone on and off the field.



PART 1

AN INTRODUCTION TO ADHD

A Distinct Combination of Characteristics

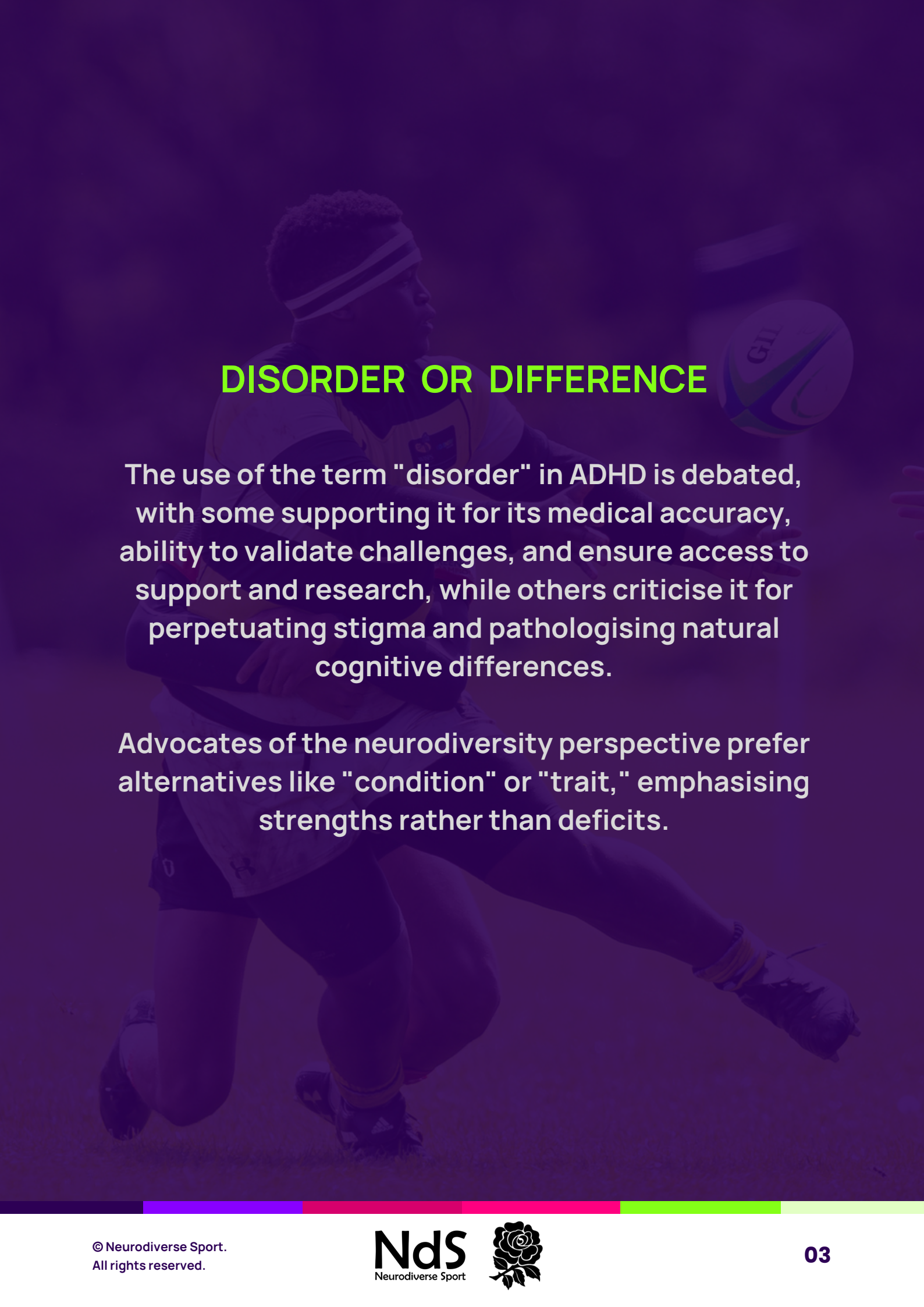
ADHD, or Attention Deficit Hyperactivity Disorder, is diagnosed when an individual exhibits a distinct profile of traits or characteristics. These traits typically fall into three key areas: inattention, hyperactivity, and impulsivity. ADHD influences how a person navigates daily life, affecting areas such as focus, executive functioning ('brain administration') emotional regulation, and activity levels.

Much like other neurodivergent conditions, ADHD presents uniquely in each person.

A Heterogeneous Condition

Much like other neurodivergent conditions, ADHD presents uniquely in each person. One individual might struggle significantly with time management but excel in creativity and problem-solving, while another might have difficulties with impulsivity but thrive in high-energy environments. Recognising and understanding these traits on a personal level is crucial for providing tailored support that honours both strengths and challenges, helping create an environment where individuals with ADHD can succeed and thrive.





DISORDER OR DIFFERENCE

The use of the term "disorder" in ADHD is debated, with some supporting it for its medical accuracy, ability to validate challenges, and ensure access to support and research, while others criticise it for perpetuating stigma and pathologising natural cognitive differences.

Advocates of the neurodiversity perspective prefer alternatives like "condition" or "trait," emphasising strengths rather than deficits.



Hyperactivity

When Internalised...

Hyperactivity isn't always external; it can manifest as racing thoughts or mental restlessness, often invisible to others. This internalised hyperactivity can be overwhelming, making it difficult for individuals to focus, relax, or sleep, as their minds feel like they're constantly in overdrive. These challenges can lead to misunderstandings, with others perceiving the person as disengaged or inattentive when, in reality, they are struggling to manage the 'noise' in their mind. Over time, this internal struggle can contribute to heightened anxiety, feelings of frustration, and difficulties with mental health, such as burnout or depression. Recognising and supporting internal hyperactivity is crucial to fostering understanding and providing effective accommodations.

Internalised hyperactivity can be overwhelming, making it difficult for individuals to focus, relax, or sleep, as their minds feel like they're constantly in overdrive.



PART 2

MYTH-BUSTING FACTS ABOUT ADHD IN RUGBY

ADHD is a complex condition often oversimplified, with outdated views and deficit-based narratives reinforcing harmful stereotypes and misunderstandings about neurodiversity. To tackle these misconceptions, we need better education, representation, and understanding. Let's begin by debunking some common myths together and promoting awareness!

Myth 1

Myth

Athletes with ADHD are too impulsive to succeed in team sports.

Fact

While impulsivity can be a challenge, it often comes with quick decision-making and a fearless attitude.

In Rugby

When coached effectively, athletes with ADHD can channel their spontaneity into strategic gameplay, reacting swiftly and decisively to on-field situations. Clear communication and structured strategies can help them harness their instincts for the team's benefit.



Myth 2

Myth

People with ADHD can't focus or stay disciplined.

Fact

Individuals with ADHD often have the ability to hyperfocus on tasks or activities they are passionate about.

In Rugby

An athlete with ADHD might struggle with repetitive drills but excel in fast-paced, high-intensity situations. By incorporating variety and maintaining engagement in training, their focus and dedication can shine.

Myth 3

Myth

ADHD is just about being hyperactive.

Fact

ADHD manifests differently for everyone, with three broad presentations including inattentive, hyperactive-impulsive, and combined types.

In Rugby

Inattentive athletes might need extra support with organising tasks or following complex instructions, while those with hyperactive-impulsive traits could excel in high-energy roles but benefit from tools to manage impulsivity. Combined-type athletes may require a blend of strategies to support focus and regulate energy levels, ensuring they thrive on and off the field.



PART 3

ADHD STRENGTHS AND CHALLENGES

Remember, ADHD manifests uniquely, so each person will experience a distinct combination of the following strengths and challenges.

AREA	STRENGTHS	CHALLENGES
Attention Regulation	Hyperfocus on tasks that are engaging or meaningful, resulting in exceptional performances.	Difficulty sustaining attention on tasks that lack immediate rewards or interest, leading to disengagement.
	Creative and innovative thinking, enabling unique approaches and fresh perspectives.	Prone to distraction from external stimuli or internal thoughts, which can disrupt productivity.
	Interest-led attention to detail, noticing elements others may overlook, and offering valuable insights or solutions.	Struggles with organising and prioritising tasks, often causing feelings of frustration or procrastination.
Impulsivity	Willingness to take risks and try new things, often driving creativity, innovation, and personal growth.	Acting without thinking, which may lead to risk-taking behaviours or social misunderstandings.
	Quick decision-making in fast-paced situations, enabling adaptability and rapid action when needed.	Struggling to wait for turns or interrupting others in conversations, potentially affecting relationships.
	Enthusiasm and spontaneity, often injecting energy, creativity, and excitement into various situations.	Difficulty pausing to consider consequences before making decisions, leading to unintentional errors.



ADHD STRENGTHS AND CHALLENGES CONTINUED...

AREA	STRENGTHS	CHALLENGES
Hyperactivity	High energy and stamina, especially for physical activities, enabling peak performance.	Restlessness or difficulty staying seated or still, which can lead to feelings of frustration or anxiety.
	Ability to multitask effectively, managing several tasks simultaneously without feeling overwhelmed.	Fidgeting, tapping, or feeling driven to move constantly, which can be disruptive in certain environments.
	Constant drive to stay productive or engaged, ensuring high levels of activity and engagement.	Internalised hyperactivity, such as racing thoughts or mental restlessness, make it hard to focus.
Emotional Regulation	Strong passion and enthusiasm for causes or interests, fuelling determination and perseverance.	Intense emotional reactions that can escalate quickly, making it difficult to stay composed.
	Resilience and determination to overcome challenges, fostering growth through adversity.	Challenges with recovering from setbacks or perceived failures, often leading to feelings of discouragement.
Executive Functioning	Ability to think flexibly and adapt to changing circumstances, allowing for creative solutions.	Problems with planning, organisation, and time management, resulting in missed deadlines.
	Strength in finding creative shortcuts or workarounds, finding ways to streamline tasks.	Forgetfulness and difficulty following through on commitments or instructions, leading to delays.



SUCCESSFUL ATHLETES WITH ADHD

Here are some examples of successful athletes with ADHD who have excelled in their fields, showcasing the potential strengths of ADHD in driving creativity, hyperfocus, and innovative approaches to challenges.

UK-Based

- **Anya Steel** – Rugby Player – ADHD (Code not specified)
- **Benny Howell** – English first-class cricketer, England, 2006–present
- **James Haskell** – Former Professional Rugby Union Player – ADHD
- **Jonathan Drane** – Paralympic judoka and Commonwealth medallist, Great Britain, 2012–2018
- **Nicola Adams** – Two-time Olympic Champion Boxer, Great Britain, 2005–2016
- **Shanaze Reade** – Three-time UCI BMX World Champion, Great Britain, 2004–2017
- **Tanya Bird** – Women’s Premiership Rugby Union Player – ADHD and Autism

‘Greatest Of All Time’

- **Justin Gatlin** – Five-time Olympic medal-winning sprinter, USA, 2002–2021
- **Michael Phelps** – Twenty-eight-time Olympic medallist swimmer, USA, 2000–2016
- **Simone Biles** – Four-time Olympic gold medallist gymnast, USA, 2013–present



PART 4

REDUCING CHALLENGES, LEVERAGE STRENGTHS

Supporting an individual with ADHD in a sports setting involves creating an environment that reduces challenges and highlights strengths.

ADHD: REDUCING CHALLENGES

Provide Simplified Instructions

Break tasks into smaller, more manageable steps with clear instructions and step-by-step guidance.



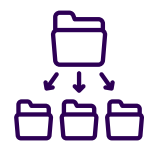
Ensure Flexibility in Routine

Create adaptable structures that balance consistency with flexibility, accommodating individuals' changing needs.



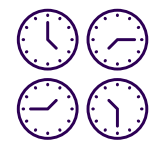
Offer Organisational Tools

Use visual aids, reminders, and organisational tools to support memory and task management,



Encourage Regular Breaks

Offer regular breaks to prevent mental fatigue and manage hyperactivity.



Minimise Distractions

Reduce distractions by creating a quiet, low-stimulus environment for focus-intensive tasks, such as team talks.



ADHD: LEVERAGING STRENGTHS

Leverage Hyperfocus

Provide tasks or challenges that allow intense concentration on areas of interest, leading to exceptional outcomes.



Nurture Intense Interests

Encourage involvement in activities that align with passions, boosting engagement and motivation.



Harness Creative Problem-Solving

Utilise innovative thinking and the ability to approach challenges from unique angles.



Channel Quick Decision-Making

Emphasise swift decision-making in dynamic situations, offering an advantage in high-pressure game scenarios.



Consider High-Energy Roles

Assign roles that require energy and multitasking, tapping into innate enthusiasm and drive.



ADHD: BUILDING CONFIDENCE

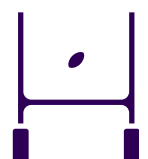
Offer Positive Feedback

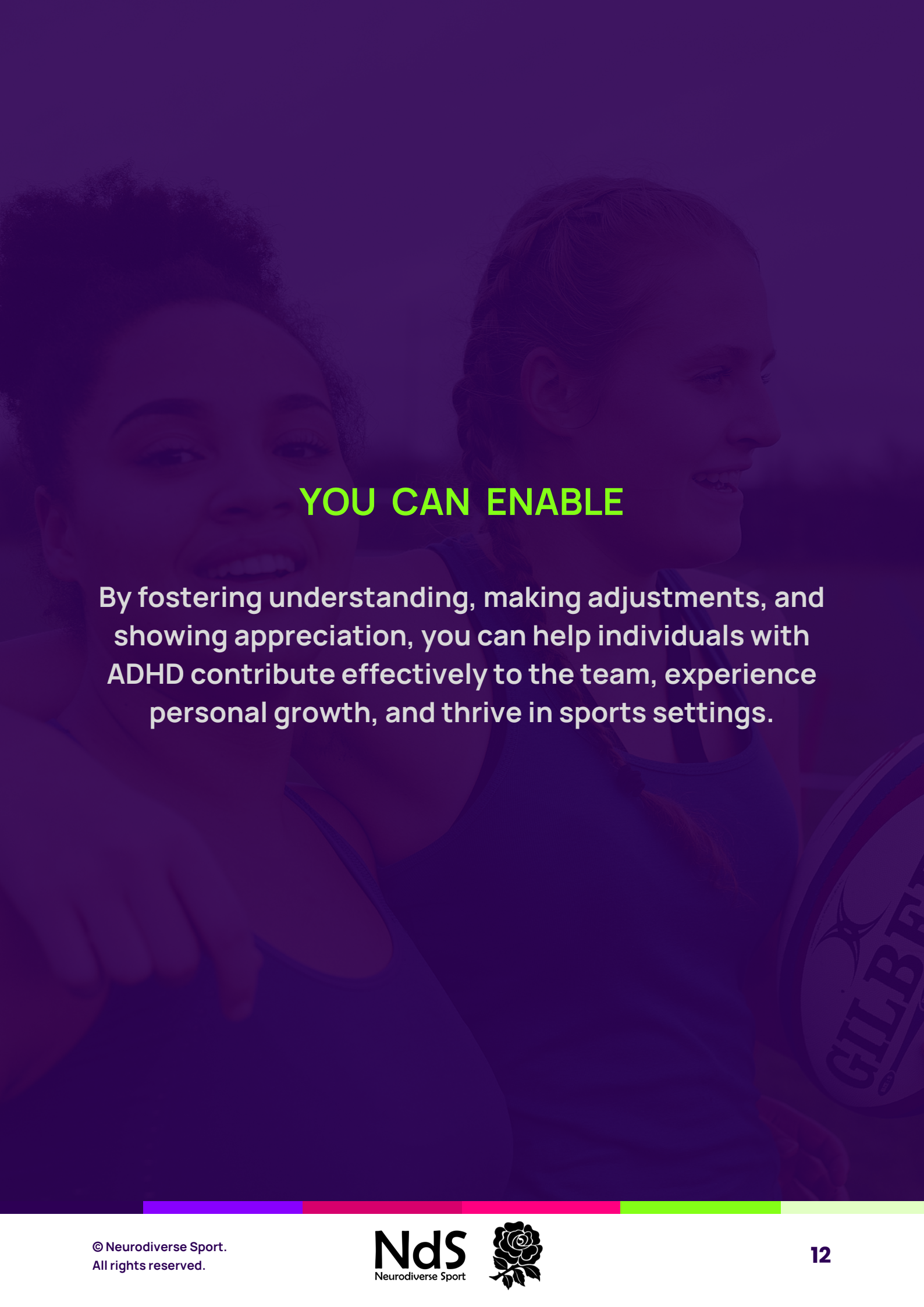
Acknowledge achievements to foster a sense of accomplishment and encourage ongoing effort.



Set Achievable Goals

Set regular achievable goals that are regularly reviewed to consistently build confidence.





YOU CAN ENABLE

By fostering understanding, making adjustments, and showing appreciation, you can help individuals with ADHD contribute effectively to the team, experience personal growth, and thrive in sports settings.



PART 5

CASE STUDY - SUPPORT IN ACTION

DANNI'S JOURNEY AS A RUGBY PLAYER WITH ADHD

Background

Danni, a 19-year-old rugby player, has always demonstrated raw talent. However, her ADHD created challenges in both training and match settings. While her coaches admired her passion and athleticism, Danni often struggled to maintain focus during drills, frequently becoming distracted or losing track of instructions. Her impulsivity sometimes led to on-field errors, such as acting without considering the consequences, and she would occasionally become frustrated when things didn't go as planned. **Her coach and teammates found her behaviour difficult to understand and were unsure how to support her.**

Danni, a player with exceptional athletic ability, struggled to stay focused in both training and match environments.

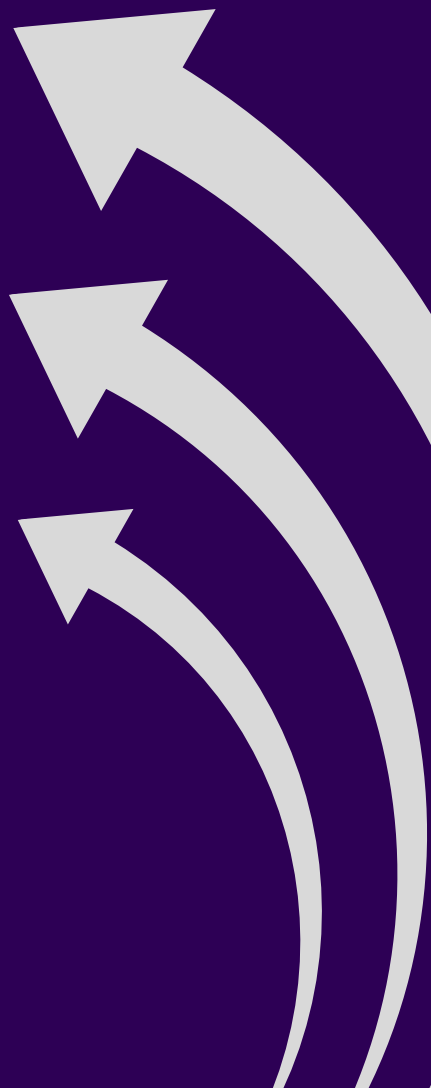


The Turning Point

Recognising the need to better support Danni, **the coaching staff took the initiative to educate themselves about ADHD.** This foundational understanding allowed Danni's coach to have a constructive one-to-one conversation with her about his experience of ADHD and how the team could best provide support. Through this dialogue, they learned that Danni often struggled to sustain attention on tasks that lacked immediate stimulation and faced challenges with impulsivity.

Danny and her coach worked together to develop a personalised support plan that balanced structured guidance with flexibility. The approach focused on minimising distractions, ensuring clear and consistent communication, and leveraging Danni's natural enthusiasm and energy to help her thrive.

Danni excelled in fast-paced situations, with a remarkable ability to think quickly and make split-second decisions on the field.



Support in Action

With the insights gained from reading and proactive conversations, the coaching team implemented several **tailored strategies** to support Danni, including:

Danni was given short, focused tasks during team training sessions with clear, actionable goals.

➡ Managing Attention and Focus

Danni was given short, focused tasks during team training sessions with clear, actionable goals.

➡ Impulse Control

By using grounding techniques, Danni was able to pause and reflect before responding in certain situations.

➡ Supportive, Empowering Environment

The team created a space where Danni could self-regulate by taking breaks when needed, reducing mental fatigue and frustration..



Growth and Development

At 21, **Danni has made remarkable strides in improving her focus, impulse control, and self-regulation on the field.** She has established a routine of using grounding techniques and participating in regular reflection sessions with her coach. Together, these efforts have helped her pause, assess the consequences of her actions, and make more thoughtful decisions instead of acting impulsively.

Her improved focus and self-regulation has brought greater consistency to both her training and matches, **allowing her strengths to truly shine.**

The combined support of her team and the strategies Danni implemented have been pivotal in helping her effectively manage her ADHD.



Conclusion

The Power of Inclusivity

Danni's journey demonstrates that, with the right support, individuals with ADHD can turn their challenges into strengths. By fostering an environment of understanding, clear communication, and self-empowerment, Danni was able to excel in rugby while also gaining the tools to manage her ADHD in both sporting and personal contexts. This case illustrates the value of leveraging individual strengths to achieve long-term success.



A Neurodiverse Sport Publication produced
in collaboration with England Rugby

With thanks to

the following members of the Neurodiverse Sport team

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Shauna Clune
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Olivia Rae
Daley Jones
Faye Brown Designs

and the following members of the Rugby Community

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Ali Boyd	Joanna Perkins	Rebecca Shea
Andy Rutherford	John Smith	Stacey Sewell
Charlotte Lloyd	Lindsey Chaplin	Stephen Garrett
Chris Spedding	Luke Cheyne	Tanya Bird
Dan Field	Lynsey Hyslop	Tim Pickard
Grant Hathaway	Mark Finnis	Tom Kidd



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